

Restart

Dual Combat Design Document

– for players who want both combo control and turn-based tactics –

Item	Description
Project	Restart
Document	System Design (with TODOs)
Version	v1.2 (added L1–L4 theory backing + design philosophy)
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0. Document History

v0.1	2026-08-12	Lin Wangru	Initial draft: single-player positioning, target experience, (
v0.2	2026-08-17	Lin Wangru	Service group layering; priority; loop users back into positioning, accep
v0.3	2026-08-18	Lin Wangru	Added experience E/F/G: rule attraction, strategic retry, nested flow loc
v1.0	2026-09-28	Lin Wangru	Full rewrite per 2026.09 design. Introduced 6 gods / Lost Time / watch sv
v1.1	2026-09-28	Lin Wangru	6 faction skills finalized; Lingmai only in turn-based; R key requires SH
v1.2	2026-09-28	Lin Wangru	Added L1-L4 theory backing for Lingmai turn-only. Added design philosophy

1. Design Rationale

「This is a JRPG where the protagonist Sheen carries a watch that switches combat between real-time action and turn-based command. The watch is both a narrative prop and a system switch. Every press causes Sheen to lose a fragment of memory – the price for the true ending.」

1.1 System Positioning

Restart is a JRPG, not an ARPG. All combat runs on the dual combat system. The traditional JRPG pain points: (1) grinding in the field, (2) boring turn-based battles. We respond with:

Field Real-time action (combos + S/A/B/C/D rating) – smooth, never tedious

Boss Forced turn-based (Attack / Skill / Ultimate / CP / Energy / Universal Passive) – strategic, calculable, learnable

Switching Sheen presses the watch; player can press R to force turn-based (Sheen must be in party)

Leveling Tied to story milestones (explore / quest / ruin / boss) – no grinding

1.2 Design Purpose

Field repetition Real-time combos + milestone leveling shifts player attention to exploration

Boss strategy Turn-based + action bar + CP + Energy – think before you act

Slow growth Milestone leveling – no farming required

Lingmai split across modes Constraint: Lingmai only works in turn-based

1.3 User Experience

30 seconds in I am in an ancient continent – 6 gods story intro

Mid-prologue Sheen appears, presses watch, world slows down – this is turn-based

Every chapter No grinding; story milestone = level up

By the first boss, the player should feel: this has depth. After losing, they can tell a friend: I lost because I forgot to interrupt his charge at phase 2. That is the target experience.

2. System Overview

2.0 JRPG System Designer Scope + 4-Layer Why Framework

Why does this design doc look more like copywriting?

Because JRPG system design and narrative design are naturally inseparable. JRPG player retention is: I believe in this world – not – this skill is strong.

Action / FPS / MOBA system designer = ~70% numerical feel + 30% balance

JRPG system designer = ~50% system design + 30% world-binding + 20% character lines / plot logic

This is not overreach, this is JRPG craft. For JRPG studios (Falcom, Atlus, SE) this world-binding skill is a plus.

This is written up front so you / interviewers / teammates know the copywriting tone is a design choice, not drift.

2.0.1 4-Layer Why Framework (used in every rule in this document)

Every rule in v1.2+ must answer four layers of "why". This is the framework I use to write each rule:

Layer	Question	Example
L1 Experience analogy	What existing game/design has done	Remembering Team's action bar system
L2 Player pain point	What specific player problem does	"Bluerüfe's edge" pain point
L3 Player psychology	Why does this rule actually work	Self-Determination game theory? competence need
L4 Experience design	What design theory / concept apply	Paradox of Choice; Ludonarrative Consistency; Flow Ch

L1 + L2 are mandatory. L3 is the core of "theory backing". L4 is the bonus that distinguishes senior designers.

2.1 System at a Glance

Module	Analogy	What it does
Dual Combat (field + boss)	Rollers on road / skates in rink	Field real-time; boss turn-based
Level System	Test scores ranking	Level tied to story nodes – no grinding
Equipment	Toolbox	Quest / ruin drops, shared by both combat modes
Lingmai + Lingcore	SRUhestree + gear sockets (turn-based only)	3 base maps, 6 factions
Watch (Lost Time)	Prop = switch = ending trigger	Sheen presses watch = switch; each press = memory loss

2.2 World Setting

JRPG demands: where are we, why this way. Our world answers: why are Sunday monsters weak, why can Sheen switch combat, why does magic exist.

Six Gods of Creation

Monday – Light God Brought light, drove away darkness. Monday: light monsters strong

Tuesday – Life God Brought life, nurtured earth. Tuesday: life monsters strong

Wednesday – Origin Goddess Brought change. Wednesday: change monsters strong

Thursday – War and Art God Brought courage and art. Thursday: craft monsters strong

Friday – Machine and Wisdom Goddess Brought the pursuit of wisdom. Friday: machine monsters strong

Saturday – Death Sovereign Declared the death of life. Saturday: death monsters strong

Sunday (Rest) All gods rest. Sunday: all monster magic suppressed, weaker than normal

Protagonist Entry

Prologue opens with Alice, captain of the female guard. Sunday monsters should be weak, but today they go berserk. Alice and guards fight in real-time (this is the field combat preview).

When things go badly, the real protagonist Sheen appears, watch in hand, presses the switch –

「Within a certain range, all monsters and allies begin acting in an ordered pattern by some special rule. The guard successfully repels the monsters.」

Two Core Settings

Lost Time (the watch) Sheen watch imposes Order on organic life within range. Press watch = switch combat mode. Each press costs Sheen memory (ties to true ending – see 3.7)

Blessed (magical users) People with magic. Most commoners cannot use it. Magitech engineering (like an industrial revolution) was born to let ordinary people use magic. Most playable characters are Blessed.

6 Factions Mirror 6 Gods

6 Lingcore factions = 6 gods (Mon to Sat). World and system are bound. Players will never ask why 6 – because creation had 6.

2.3 System Mindmap

[Combat System

+-- Real-Time (Field): combos + rating S/A/B/C/D (Devil May Cry 5 reference)

+-- Turn-Based (Boss / R key): Attack / Skill / Ultimate / CP / Energy / Universal

Passive (Trails reference)

[Growth System

+-- Level: tied to world milestones, no grinding

+-- Equipment: quest / ruin, shared by both modes

+-- Lingmai: 3 slots x core Lingcore + 2 free Lingcore, with 5 rune branches

** Only effective in turn-based **

[6 Factions: Blessing / Tenacity / Origin / Dominion / Precision / Undead]

3. Detailed Design

This chapter is for programmers / artists / numerical designers. Module by module.

3.0 Module Overview

No.	Module	One-liner	Status
M1	Dual combat switch	Sheen watch / R key	Designed, implementing
M2	Real-time (field)	Combos + rating + dodge + hit stun	Designed
M3	Turn-based (boss)	Attack / Skill / Ultimate / CP / Energy	Designed, Universal Passive
M4	Milestone leveling	Story node = level up	Designed
M5	Equipment	Quest / ruin, both modes share	Planned
M6	Lingmai + Lingcore	+6Rune free-build (turn-based only)	v1.2 with L1-L4 theory
M7	Watch Lost Time	Switch + memory loss + ending	v1.1 finalized

3.1 M1 Dual Combat Switch

What it is

Sheen presses the watch: combat switches from real-time combos to turn-based command. Press again (or leave the area) to switch back. In narrative: imposing Order. In system: mode switch.

Switching Rules

Method	Trigger	Result
Field default	No input	Real-time combo mode (field)
R key manual	Sheen in party + press R	Force turn-based (anytime)
Elite / Boss encounter	Enemy-tagged enemy	Forced turn-based + entry cinematic
Boss phase change	Boss script trigger	Brief real-time pursuit cinematic allowed
Return to real-time	Close command menu	Resume movement, HP / persistent Buffs preserved

Why this way

Field uses real-time for no-grind flow. Boss uses turn-based because bosses are tough and need strategy. The JRPG soul: give the player time to think before acting.

R Key Hard Constraint: Sheen Must Be In Party

Star: R key hard constraint. Player can press R anytime to switch to turn-based, but Sheen must be in the party.

Star: Story branch. Mid-game the party splits into two routes – on the route where Sheen is absent, R key does not work. Must clear with real-time combos.

Star: Design intent. R key becomes Sheen value, not a free switch anyone can do.

To complete

- ☐ 【待补完】Enter-turn-based cinematic length (suggest < 3 sec)
- ☐ 【待补完】Story branch chapters / party composition

3.2 M2 Real-Time Combat (Field)

What it is

In field combat, player uses keyboard / gamepad directly. Action game feel reference: Devil May Cry 5 combo system and rating.

How it plays

Basics Attack / dodge / block / skill – 3 to 8 second loop per character

Combo cancels Cancel previous action at specific frames to extend combo

Rating S / A / B / C / D per battle. Affects drops.

Readable risk Enemy attack wind-up + range highlight – player can see then react

Must never happen

Long menus in field Drives away action-light players

Combo-stacking kills boss Empty out turn-based meaning

Field eats Lingmai builds Lingmai only in turn-based – field gets only base stats

3.3 M3 Turn-Based Command (Boss / Elite)

What it is

Boss / elite battle (or R key manual switch), combat goes turn-based. Reference: Trails action bar system, but we removed: Magic, Defend command, Burst, Quartz burst.

Command Menu (per your design)

Command	Cost	Effect
Attack	None	Basic physical attack
Skill	CP (common action resource)	Character unique move
Ultimate	CP + Energy	Big move
Item	Item slot	Heal / cleanse / buff etc.

CP Common action resource. Earned in field by hits / perfect dodges. Used in boss battle.

Energy High-cost resource (Ultimate). Used at key moments in boss battle.

Universal Passive Character talent passives, always on, no select needed.

3.4 M4 Milestone Leveling

What it is

Traditional JRPG: level up = grind XP bar. Our game: level up = story milestone trigger. Explore to a node / complete a key event, character auto-gains 1 level.

How it runs

Milestone nodes First time entering new area / completing key quest / unlocking ruin / after boss battle

Level cap Limited by world exploration (more explore = higher cap)

R key uses How many times Sheen can R = tied to level / exploration

3.5 M5 Equipment System

How to get

Quest reward From main / side quest completion

Ruin exploration Rare equipment in ruins (map markers)

Planned other Shop / crafting / character bond gifts

3.6 M6 Lingmai + Lingcore + Runes (core growth)

StarStar: All effects in this module only work in turn-based mode. StarStar Field real-time combat gets no Lingmai buffs, only base stats (attack / defense).

Design Philosophy Pillar (v1.2):

灵脉仅回合制 -> 后期无回合制 (真结局前玩家失去 R 键) -> 玩家从机制层理解希恩不可替代

This is the load-bearing design decision. It binds: (1) growth system, (2) narrative climax, (3) ending mechanic. Without this constraint, the Sheen protagonist concept becomes decorative instead of mechanically essential.

4-Layer Why: Lingmai only in Turn-Based

Layer	Reasoning
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L1 Experience analogy	Reference Trails series: Skill slots only work in AT battle. But we push this further
L2 Player pain point	Solve: action players using growth builds to clear the field, bypassing turn-based.
L3 Player psychology	(CORE) Once Lingmai enters real-time combat, it becomes a strategy game — that conf
L4 Experience design	(DEEPEST) reason this philosophy runs through the whole game: full-completion playt

What it is

This is the core of our growth system. Each character has 3 Lingmai slots; each slot holds one Lingcore.

Structure

- Lingmai 3 slots per character
- Core Lingcore 1 per Lingmai (faction fixed by character class)
- Other Lingcores 2 free Lingcores for build
- Branches 5 branch slots under each core Lingcore
- Runes Small runes filling branches for base stat (shop only)

6 Lingcore Factions Skill Focus (v1.1 finalized)

Faction	God	One-liner	Skill / Passive direction
Blessing	Tue Life God	Heal group / buff group / resource control	Group heal / (Energy/EP) team buff
Tenacity	Mon Light God	HP + dual defense / regen / shield	Damage reduction / heal / counter on hit
Origin	Wed Origin Goddess	Resource control (max EP / EP cost reduction)	EP economy / special under-boosting skills
Dominion	Sat Death Sovereign	Turn order grab / burst damage	Stun / steal turn / Ultimate boost
Precision	Fri Machine Wisdom Goddess	Focused damage / combo boost / long-range hit	Origin priority / offstacking damage
Undead	Thu War Art God	Unit summon / debuff	Summon skeleton / debuff / turn extend

Why these 6

- Defense sustain Blessing (group sustain) + Tenacity (single sustain)
- Resource control Origin (EP economy) + Dominion (turn economy)
- Output rhythm Precision (steady crit) + Undead (summon / debuff for tempo)

How to obtain

- Lingcore Quest reward / special event / ruin / shop (4 ways)
- Runes Shop only (this is the monetization point)

Verification Metrics

- Boss retry count Avg < 3 (Lingmai build helps turn-based strategy)
- Late-game real-time rating Avg >= B (no Lingmai but still passable)
- Player survey Players write "I understood why Sheen sacrificed" (narrative-mechanic)

unity achieved)

3.7 M7 Watch Lost Time (system + narrative)

StarStar: Watch is narrative prop + system switch + true-ending trigger. StarStar Sheen press watch = switch combat mode. Each press costs Sheen memory (ties to true ending – not detailed in this version).
-- This is the JRPG system designer cost: making the player believe this world.

Design Philosophy Pillar (continued):
The watch is not just a switch. It is the protagonist's sacrifice mechanism. Combined with M6 (Lingmai turn-only) + late-game "R key unavailable", the watch becomes the symbol of "what Sheen gives up so the player can win". Memory loss accumulates -> true ending only available to those who relied on Sheen -> the narrative of "Sheen sacrificed himself for the player" is mechanically enacted, not just scripted.

What it is

Sheen watch. Narratively: pressing it imposes Order on organic life within range – the narrative reason for combat mode switch. System-wise: watch = mode switch + true ending input.

How it works (v1.1 finalized)

Timing	Action	Result
Field	Sheen presses watch	Switch to turn-based. Press again to revert.
Boss battle	Sheen presses watch	Adjust action bar tempo (not a manual mode switch since scene
R key	Player presses R	Force turn-based (prereq: Sheen in party)
Late-game	Plot triggers	Watch cannot be used; R key disabled; player must fight all r
After boss	Auto settle	This watch use recorded to memory-loss counter

R Key Hard Constraint

Star: Who can press R. Sheen must be in party.
Star: When R fails. Mid-game the party splits into two routes – on the route where Sheen is absent, R key does nothing. Must clear with real-time combos.
Star: Late-game (pre-true-ending). Watch and R key both disabled – the "Sheen sacrifice" mechanic.
Star: Design intent. R key = Sheen value, not a free switch.

Why watch not a button

JRPG players are sensitive to why-can-I-switch. A real item + narrative explanation beats a plain button.

Memory Mechanic (mention only, no detail)

Each time Sheen uses the watch, he loses a fragment of memory. This is a key input to true ending judgment. Use watch more = clear easier = lose more memory = different ending. Specific thresholds and ending branches will be expanded in section 5 ending table (not in this version, TBD).

4. Other Requirements

4.1 Program

Combat mode state machine Watch press = state switch; freeze current input, archive
Swift combo state
Action bar (AT) impl Readable / reservable / interruptible; reservation editable
Resource (CP + Energy) loop Field hits earn CP; turn-based spends CP; Energy is
high-cost
Buff / damage layering Field and turn-based share one damage formula
Lingmai filter Field real-time gets no Lingmai; only turn-based (script filter /
state machine)
R key hard constraint Check Sheen in party; if not, R key invalid (UI grey + system
feedback text)
Late-game watch disable Story trigger disables watch + R; must be testable
Watch use counter Global counter; links to true ending table
Snapshot + checkpoint Auto-save before boss; failure rolls back to pre-battle
resources

4.2 Art

Dual-mode character action set Each character needs: real-time (attack / dodge /
hit) + turn-based (idle / cast / ultimate)
Watch UI Sheen waist watch; battle can light up; memory loss = dial grime (visual
cue)
Turn-based entry cinematic Enemy pressure field + time slow + action bar lights up
6 faction Lingcore icons Blessing (life green) / Tenacity (light gold) / Origin
(change purple) / Dominion (death red) / Precision (machine silver) / Undead (craft
bronze)
World map 6 god statues scattered in 6 areas (each area = a day of week)

4.3 Design

Copy 6 god lore / watch narrative / boss lines / Sheen post-memory-loss lines
Numerical Action bar formula / level formula / Lingcore table / CP economy / 6
faction skills
Script config Boss config (phase mechanics / 1 new rule per battle / tutorial
embedded)
Tutorial level Prologue one basic boss (teaches 1 rule only)

4.4 QA

Must test Mode switch no glitch; R invalid when Sheen absent; Lingmai only turn-based; late-game watch disable; watch counter correct; milestone trigger no miss; rune slot no overflow

Experience test Player understands watch within 5 min; player can say which rule lost at; player understands R failure on split route; player feels Sheen sacrifice in late-game

Performance Mode switch no fps drop (target: stable 60 fps)

5. Activity Expectation

Single-player, no operations. This chapter outlines DLC / version targets.

5.1 Version Plan

Version	Content	Playable hours
v1.0 Main	Prologue + Ch1 + Ch2	20-30 hours
v1.1 Expansion	Tika joins + mobile workshop + party split story	+ 5-8 hours
v1.2 True Ending	Watch threshold unlock + memory-loss cinematic + late-game boss Sheen sacrifice	+ 3-5 hours
v2.0 New character	Add new playable (Katerina etc. in sub-doc)	+ 10 hours

5.2 Player Expectation Metrics

- Completion rate First week > 40% (milestone leveling avoids grind wall)
- New game+ rate > 20% (true ending depends on watch count)
- Boss retry count Avg < 3 (means strategy readable, not stat wall)
- R key use frequency Field R usage frequency (measure whether field is really tedious)
- Late-game review sentiment Players write "I understand why Sheen sacrificed" in surveys

6. Risk Estimation

6.1 User Risk

Risk	Prob	Impact	Mitigation
JRPG old players cant adapt to dual combat	M	H	Prologue watch debut + tutorial; shared growth keeps both sides val
Action players hate turn-based	M	H	Boss entry cinematic; settlement uses rule-not-damage
Field wants Lingmai build	M	M	Field no Lingmai (program filter); JRPG players agree (build = boss
Late-game Sheen sacrifice feels artificial	L	H	Build up sacrifice throughout Ch2; warning signs in Ch1
R key becomes must-press	L	M	Boss forced turn-based already enough; R is option not must
Try to please everyone	L	VH	Apply service priority on conflict

6.2 Technical Risk

Mode switch fps drop UE4 BP state machine; target: 30-min boss 60 fps stable

Action bar + reservation complex Suggest ScriptableObject config table driven; unit test

Lingmai slot bug Slot mutual exclusion rule; field filter is mandatory test

R key Sheen not in party Hard constraint needs program + UI double check

Late-game watch disable Story trigger must atomically disable both watch and R key

6.3 Doc Risk

Memory loss -> true ending map not written Must complete - core plot

6 faction specific skills not listed No impact on framework, but impact on numerical landing

R key script boundary Which field scenes open R / close R - need per-chapter script align

7. Project Management

7.1 Version Priority

Priority	Module	Reason
P0	Dual combat switch + turn-based combat	Without these the game cant run
P0	Milestone leveling	No-grinding is core selling point
P0	Lingmai turn-only constraint + R key constraints	ARE design strategy + late-game watchcount disable end
P1	Field combo + rating	Field feel source
P1	Watch count -> memory -> ending	True ending mechanic
P2	Lingmai 6 faction complete numbers	Post-launch balance
P2	Equipment affix pool	Post-launch expand

7.2 This Iteration TODO List

- Watch count -> memory -> true ending branch map
- Level formula (explore -> level cap)
- 6 faction specific skill / ultimate list
- Per-character combo table (attack hits / cancel window)
- Which field scenes open R / close R
- Late-game Sheen sacrifice chapter pacing
- Tutorial level script + cinematic length

- END -

v1.2 iteration of 2026.09 design. Added L1-L4 theory backing for the load-bearing rule (Lingmai turn-only), and added the design philosophy pillar linking M6 / M7 / late-game into a single coherent intent: by losing the build system in late-game, players retroactively understand why Sheen is irreplaceable.